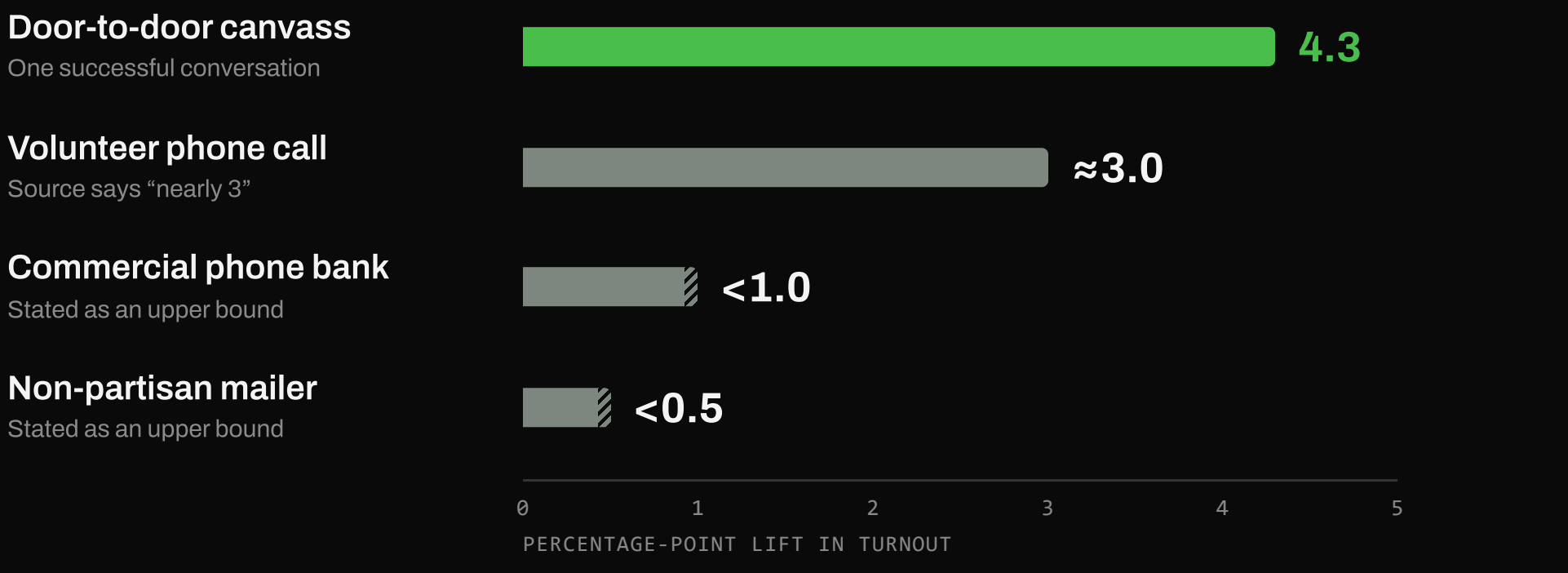
FIELD EVIDENCE · TURNOUT EXPERIMENTS

THE CONVERSATION WORKS. THE DOOR HAS TO OPEN FIRST.

Decades of randomised field experiments have measured what a stranger at a door is worth. The finding is not that the pitch is powerful. It is that the pitch is the part you are least able to change on any given morning.



4.3 pts when the conversation actually happens × **~25%** of the doors you knock are answered = **≤1 pt** across the whole list you set out to reach

Hatched ends mark the two figures the source states as ceilings rather than estimates. These measure voter turnout, not sales conversion — the transferable part is the shape, not the coefficient.

OUR READ

Every number in the top half is fixed before the day starts. The only one that moves is the one in the bottom right, and it moves because of how many doors got knocked. That is the law of averages with a measured coefficient attached to it, which is rarer than the phrase suggests.

Source: Alan S. Gerber and Gregory A. Huber, “Getting Out the Vote Is Tougher Than You Think,” *Stanford Social Innovation Review*, 7 March 2016.
Read first-hand 14 September 2026. Gerber is a co-author of the underlying Yale field-experiment programme.

SURGE